The Isabel Fish

By Julie Orringer

Crime and punishment. That is the pattern between my brother Sage and me. A quiet private criminal justice system, with Sage as judge, jury, jailer and executioner. Our system allows multiple punishments for the same crime. If, in a real court, I'd been proven guilty of killing Isabel, I would have gotten my punishment and been left to live with it. In the world of Sage and me, however, I must pay and pay.

INTRODUCTION

Isabel is dead . . . in fact she dies twice in this story. Once with Maddy and once at the hands of Maddy's brother Sage. But it is Maddy, a normal 14-year-old little sister, who tells her story of just how hard it is to deal with the death of a friend – especially when your brother holds you responsible for that death.

And the story unfolds slowly -- as if underwater -- in The Isabel Fish by Julie Orringer

I am the canker of my brother Sage's life. He has told me so in no uncertain terms. Tonight on the way to

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our first scuba class, he can't stop talking about the horrible fates that might befall me underwater. This, even though he knows how scared I am after what happened last November.

"You could blow out your eardrums," he says. "Or your lungs might implode from the pressure. Did you know that one in twelve scuba divers gets attacked by sharks?"

Sage is sixteen, plays drums, smokes unfiltered cigarettes, and drives his beat-up black Pinto to school every morning. He sees me as a problem, a younger and more stupid version of himself, and a girl, not popular, sort of plain. He used to be cruel to me in the normal sibling sense, but now it's worse. He is far from forgetting Isabel, and who can blame him? She'd been his girlfriend for six months before the accident, and it's only been four months since. Four months is a short time in the grand scheme of things, shorter than it's taken me to grow twenty-six fighting fish from eggs for my science experiment.

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I got the eggs one month before the accident. When I showed them to Isabel, red and clumped together in a small tank, she laughed and said she could hardly believe that bunch of caviar would become real animals. Well, guess what? They are now. Every day I feed them and give them liquid vitamins and alter their blood pressure with drugs, and still get my homework done and make it to school just as if I were fully recovered. Which I'm not, in many ways.

My parents are aware of this. As a kind of remedy, they came up with the idea of a spring-break trip to St. Maarten in the Dutch Virgin Islands. They've been talking about the problem between Sage and me for months, our mom trying to give us counseling, our dad distracting us with jokes. Now scuba lessons, in preparation for the trip.

What our parents don't understand is that their son has become cruel and unusual, and he shows no sign of changing. "Anyone could f*** with your tank underwater," he says. "One turn of a knob, that's all it would take."

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I remember being in Isabel's car with the water coming in, filling my mouth with its cold fishy taste, and me groping in the dark for my seat belt, my lungs already hot and tight, and Isabel in the seat beside me bleeding into the darkness. Sage must know what I'm thinking about, but he won't look at me or say anything more.

At the YMCA I follow Sage into the lobby, where the chlorine smell of the pool stops me cold. Sage doesn't notice. He doesn't even look back. He just disappears down the hall toward the men's locker room, leaving me standing there alone. Tonight, for the first time, I'll begin to know what my fish have known all their lives: how to breathe underwater. When I get calm enough I go to the women's locker room and find an empty locker. When I go to St. Maarten I will have my own fins, according to my father; we have already looked at examples and I have admired a translucent blue pair with a matching mask. They seem like they'd be almost invisible underwater.

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Looking at those fins made it easy to imagine swimming, but now that I'm here at the Y it seems crazy. Sure, in St. Maarten there are a lot of fish you can see living their lives around coral reefs if you happen to know how to scuba. That kind of thing is attractive to an ichthyophile like me. But I am also a person who almost drowned. When my dad told me about St. Maarten, with its great diving, I wanted to ask if he and my mother were crazy. Did they really think I would voluntarily walk into the ocean and let it close over my head? "Scuba?"

"We think it'll be good for you," my mother said. "We think it'll help you form positive associations with water."

As I get into my tank suit I cannot help noticing the mistakes of my body. My chest is too flat, my legs too skinny, and there is a scar running the length of my left thigh. Under the water, car metal sliced me in a neat line. I didn't even feel it. Only at the edge of the pond afterward did I look down and see the blood.

I realize there are probably only ten or fifteen minutes between me and the experience of getting

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underwater again. For a moment I wish my mother or father were here. Then I remember I am fourteen and lucky to be alive.

But nothing has prepared me for the experience of actually seeing the pool. Sage is nowhere to be seen. I sit down on a bench and put my head between my knees to feel better. The instructor tells us we'll have fifteen minutes of laps. But I look at my feet waving in the water and wonder if I'm going to brick. It's one of the main reasons I didn't want to take the class, the possibility of me freaking out and Sage having to take me home. Sage probably expects me to freak out too. . . I will not drown here with all these people watching, and me a good swimmer. I will not drown here . . . .

Finally it's my turn. I stand at the edge of the pool and pretend there is no water behind me at all, but instead my bed with the quilt I wrap myself in when I get depressed, and there will be no moment when the water cover me, and I will not remember the plunge in the car as we hit the surface and started going down.

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"Go!" cries the instructor, and I push off the edge. I plunge backward into the cold shock of water and sink almost immediately. My arms and legs go numb with panic, and my mouth fills with the bleach taste of pool water. I feels like I'm going down to that place where I was before, the cold dark pond on that November night, and if I go down father still I will reach Isabel, her hair floating mermaidlike around her.

All I could think about was how mad Sage would be on our way home. Once again I'd given him evidence of what a non-hero I am. Both of us can plainly see how I might have failed at a crucial moment, missed my chance to pull Isabel out of the car. The thing the police told him, the thing the autopsy confirmed, was that she was already unconscious and wedged into the crushed driver's side, the steering wheel pinning her ribs. It might have been possible for me to pull her out, but if I'd tried, I might have drowned too. And she might not have survived anyway. Everyone says I did the right thing by swimming up and climbing out to run for

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help. Still I know Sage blames me, and in my heart I agree.

In my room, my science-experiment fish seem to be sleeping in their plastic containers. I've tried to learn everything they can teach me about the chemistry of anger, what makes it ebb and flow, how it can be controlled. TO be professional I tried not to name my science experiment fish, but then I realized the coincidence of there being 26 of them, one for each letter of the alphabet, and now they all have names. The Isabel fish is in the experimental group, fed a calming drug a couple times a day. The Sage fish is a control, mean and small with high blood pressure. I pity these fish, them not knowing what's going on and being in isolation except during the aggression trials. I keep telling myself [Sage] cannot be angry at me forever, though maybe I am wrong.

I go into my bathroom, close the door, and though I don't have time to cry, I cry anyway.

[and remember . . .]

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(FLASHBACK)

I would never have gone along if I hadn't been standing around in the garage with Sage and Isabel when Ty drove up. There was talk about going to check out a new hot tub. Ty worked weekends as a hot tub installer and knew where all the tubs were – places where people were building houses – sometimes he got the tubs hooked up weeks before the owners moved in.

Everyone was excited except me. I'd been having a great time there in the garage, and now everyone was going to leave. I turned to go inside, and that was when Isabel said, "Hey, Maddy, you can come if you want." So I ran inside to get a suit and towel, and then we were off, all piled in Isabel's Toyota. Isabel singing along with the radio. I felt lucky and cool and older. I took a breath and looked up at the stars. It was November.

I headed for the Jacuzzi as if this were the kind of think I did all the time. The water steamed and rolled and burbled around us. [But] then, as if he couldn't stand that people were talking to me and acting like I belonged there, Sage had to start telling the story

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about my 5th birthday – the pool story. . . . I look in the pool and there's Maddy with this peaceful expression on her face. Our mom got everyone out of the pool to go in and have cake. Everyone was like, 'Why can't we swim anymore/" Meanwhile, Maddy tried to act like she hadn't don it. She still won't admit it, will you Maddy?' I called her the Mad Pisser that whole summer." He wouldn't let it rest. He kept poking me in the shoulder and saying, "Think you can hold it?" . . . until Isabel climbed out of the tub.

"Why do you have to be such an asshole?" she said.

"It was funny . . . Wasn't it funny?"

"It wasn't funny," Isabel said. The next minute floodlights were flashing and a shrill alarm was screaming. The house security system had gone off. Suddenly everyone was screaming and running around. I was so scared, Isabel had to grab my hand and run us to the front of the house where her car was parked. "What about Sage?" I said.

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"He can find another ride." Then she hit the gas and we were off. We turned in at Gettyswood Townhomes. Isabel laid on the gas, and as we came around the curve near the pond I felt the jolt of the curb and a sudden hollow rush in my chest and we were airborne.

The car hit the pond nose-first. The windshield crunched and everything was dark and water poured in through the open windows, so cold it erased every part of me it touched, and suddenly it was in my mouth with its pond-scum taste and I couldn't breathe. In the darkness I felt for Isabel, and my hands brushed something warm and soft, but I couldn't make my fingers hold on to anything. My lungs began to burn. I shrugged out of the seatbelt and felt for the edge of the open window, pushing through, trying to kick up to where the moon wavered. I struggled through what seemed like think black hones, broke the surface, breathed, swam to the edge. Kneeling on the wet grass, I coughed out water, waiting to see Isabel come up. I screamed to her. I got up onto the numb block of my feet and ran

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toward the townhouse, toward a phone, shouting for help.

(END FLASHBACK)

God only know how he killed them, but when I get home from school I find eleven of my fighting fish dead, the Sage fish and Isabel fish among them. And though I don't want to let myself cry, I do, because they're dead beyond the reach of hope or science, and Sage is the one who did it. After dinner, I take [them] and walk the mile to the pond. It's the first time I've been to the pond since the accident. Though I know the car was dragged out months ago, I imagine it there beneath the surface of the water, Isabel still trapped inside. It's impossible to believe how gone she is, how untouchable.

On the way to scuba that night I watch Sage as he drives . . . "You can't just not mention the fish, Sage. You can't pretend nothing happened."

"Maddy, I'm an asshole. I admit it."

"You make me wish I died instead of her."

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Finally he speaks again, so quiet I have to lean close to hear him. "I can't believe I turned out to be such a shitty person," he says. "I wasn't even nice to *her*. I was a terrible boyfriend. I got mad at her for no reason. I didn't listen to her enough. I forgot her birthday. I made fun of her car.

"You weren't a terrible boyfriend, I say. "Isabel loved you. I could see it."

"We're going to be late," Sage says.

The instructor says we're going to do a five-minute dive and tells everyone to get into wetsuits. We learn how to attached the regulator to the tank, how to turn on the air and how to test the regulator by pushing the purge button. The air from the tank is metallic and very dry.

Finally it is time again for all of us to get into the water. Sage moves close to me as we line up to splash in . . . me trying not to look over the edge into the mouth of the water. "Quit thinking about last time," he says. "It's going to be different. Practice measuring your breaths, like she told us."

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Together we fall back and splash down. When I think of Isabel this time it's not as a mermaid but as the living girlfriend of my brother. She would have like to see us diving, Sage and me. We treat water, watching each other through our masks. I cannot see his eyes, but I can see reflected small and blue, a girl wearing swim fins and a metal tank, self-contained and breathing underwater.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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